



2025 Trial Examination



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ENGLISH

Units 3 & 4 – Question and Answer Book

VCE Examination

Reading time: **15 minutes**

Writing time: **3 hours**

Approved materials

- an English and/or bilingual printed dictionary

Materials supplied

- Task book of 17 pages

Instructions

- Write your responses in English.
- You may keep this Task Book.

Students are **not** permitted to bring mobile phones and/or any unauthorised electronic devices into the examination room.

Contents	pages
Section A (1 question, 20 marks)	2-7
Section B (1 question, 20 marks)	8-12
Section C (1 question, 20 marks)	13-16
Assessment criteria	17

Section A – Analytical response to a text**Instructions**

- You must write an analytical response to a selected text on **one** of the topics (either **i** or **ii**) provided for that text.
- Your response should engage with the ideas, concerns and values raised by the topic and be supported by close reference to the text.
- If your selected text is a collection of poetry or short stories, you may write on several poems or stories, or on **at least two** in close detail. In the Answer Book, indicate which text you have chosen to write on and whether you have chosen to answer **i** or **ii**.
- Refer to the assessment criteria on page 17.
- Section A is worth one-third of the total marks for the examination.

Text list**1. Bad Dreams and Other Stories**

by Tessa Hadley

2. Born a Crime

by Trevor Noah

3. Chronicle of a Death Foretold

by Gabriel Garcia Marquez

4. False Claims of Colonial Thieves

by John Kinsella and Charmaine Papertalk Green

5. Flames

by Robbie Arnott

6. Ghost Wall

by Sarah Moss

7. Go, Went, Gone

by Jenny Erpenbeck

8. High Ground

directed by Stephen Johnson

9. Jane Eyre

by Charlotte Bronte

10. My Brilliant Career

by Miles Franklin

11. New and Selected Poems, Volume One

by Mary Oliver

12. Oedipus the King

by Sophocles

13. Rainbow's End

by Jane Harrison

14. Requiem for a Beast

by Matt Ottley

15. Sunset Boulevard

directed by Billy Wilder

16. The Complete Stories

by David Malouf

17. The Erratics

by Vicki Laveau-Harvie

18. The Memory Police

by Yoko Ogawa

19. Twelfth Night

by William Shakespeare

20. We Have Always Lived in the Castle

by Shirley Jackson

1. Bad Dreams and Other Stories by Tessa Hadley

- i. Hadley's stories portray the inexpressible emotional pain that many women endure in a conservative patriarchal society.

Discuss.

OR

- ii. Maturity comes at a cost of innocence in Hadley's stories.

Do you agree?

2. Born a Crime by Trevor Noah

- i. 'Don't fight the system, mock the system.'

Humour plays an essential role in Trevor Noah's *Born a Crime*. Discuss.

OR

- ii. Despite difficulties and challenges growing up, Noah's portrait of South Africa is ultimately a sympathetic one.

Do you agree?

3. Chronicle of a Death Foretold by Gabriel Garcia Marquez

- i. In *Chronicle of a Death Foretold*, Márquez portrays a society where collective guilt outweighs individual responsibility.

Discuss.

OR

- ii. In *Chronicle of a Death Foretold*, the pursuit of honour is a destructive force.

Do you agree?

4. False Claims of Colonial Thieves by Charmaine Papertalk Green and John Kinsella

- i. Despite the disruption and destruction of colonisation, the poetry of Papertalk Green and Kinsella offers hope.

Do you agree?

OR

- ii. *False Claims of Colonial Thieves* confronts its readers with deep fractures in the idea of a unified Australian identity.

Discuss.

5. Flames by Robbie Arnott

- i. *Flames* explores the tragic consequences of repressed grief.

Discuss.

OR

- ii. Although *Flames* evokes magic realism, the narrative is grounded in the real world.

Discuss.

6. Ghost Wall by Sarah Moss

- i. How does *Ghost Wall* portray the influence of society on an individual's need for power and control?

OR

- ii. 'I felt Dad's gaze on me and knew with a shiver what he was thinking. My daughter. Break her and stake her to the bog, stop her before she gets away.'
- Sarah Moss depicts the dangers of obsession within *Ghost Wall*.
Discuss.

7. Go, Went, Gone by Jenny Erpenbeck

- i. *Go, Went, Gone* suggests that it is not through pity, but through empathy, that people may come to a true understanding of one another.
Do you agree?

OR

- ii. 'If you don't sleep through half the morning, [a day] can be very long indeed.'
- Time is a benefit for those who are privileged, and a burden for those who are not.
Discuss.

8. High Ground by Stephen Johnson

- i. How does the Australian landscape enhance the narrative and messages in *High Ground*?

OR

- ii. *High Ground* explores the tension between justice and revenge.
Discuss.

9. Jane Eyre by Charlotte Bronte

- i. *Jane Eyre* demonstrates that society's values are determined by those of wealth and power.
Do you agree?

OR

- ii. 'I wanted a safe asylum.'
- The women in *Jane Eyre* are both physically and psychologically isolated.
To what extent do you agree?

10. My Brilliant Career by Miles Franklin

- i. The ambitions for a brilliant career shape the actions and decisions of characters in *My Brilliant Career*.

To what extent do you agree?

OR

- ii.

My Brilliant Career explores the challenges of marriage, love and desire.
Discuss.

11. New and Selected Poems, Volume One by Mary Oliver

- i. Mary Oliver's poetry is primarily concerned with the relationship between human beings and nature.

To what extent do you agree?

OR

- ii. 'Tell me, what is it you plan to do / with your one wild and precious life?'

Mary Oliver's poetry explores the meaning of life.

Discuss.

12. Oedipus the King by Sophocles

- i. 'So much for prophecy, it's neither here nor there.'

The play *Oedipus the King* proposes that divine will is absolute.

Discuss.

OR

How does *Oedipus the King* suggest that mortals are victims of their circumstances?

13. Rainbow's End by Jane Harrison

- i. Jane Harrison's play *Rainbow's End* explore the tension between autonomy and resistance.

To what extent do you agree?

OR

- ii. "My girl.. A graduate"

In *Rainbow's End*, how do the characters' dreams and aspirations serve as a coping mechanism for their challenging circumstances?

14. Requiem for a Beast by Matt Ottley

- i. To what extent is personal moral choice at the centre of *Requiem for a Beast*?

OR

- ii. 'I think of the Minotaur, the Centaur, those strange creatures that have haunted my dreams since childhood.'

What role does mythology play in the meaning of Ottley's multimodal text?

15. Sunset Boulevard directed by Billy Wilder

- i. Wilder's film *Sunset Boulevard* is a cynical portrayal of Hollywood.
Discuss.

OR

- ii. In *Sunset Boulevard* people play both the victim and villain.
To what extent do you agree?

16. The Complete Stories by David Malouf

- i. To what extent do the stories end with a sense of hope and transformation for the protagonists?

OR

- ii. Malouf's stories highlight the importance of self-knowledge.
Discuss.

17. The Erratics by Vicki Laveau-Harvie

- i. *The Erratics* suggests that there may be hope even in dysfunctional families.
Do you agree?

OR

- ii. *The Erratics* suggests that the desire for total control can be destructive.
Discuss.

18. The Memory Police by Yoko Ogawa

- i. In *The Memory Police*, the loss of memory signifies the erosion of individuality and personal identity.
Do you agree?

OR

- ii. *The Memory Police* serves as a commentary on the nature of power and control.
Discuss.

19. Twelfth Night by William Shakespeare

- i. Social class plays a significant role in shaping the relationships in *Twelfth Night*.
Discuss.

OR

- ii. *Twelfth Night* celebrates the chaos and unpredictability of love.
Do you agree?

20. We Have Always Lived in the Castle by Shirley Jackson

- i. 'All cat stories start with this statement: "My mother, who was the first cat, told me this..."'
How does the reliability of the narration influence reader understanding of the novella?

OR

- ii. It is not just the Blackwood family that is dysfunctional, but the whole community.
Discuss.

End of Section A

Section B – Creating a text**Instructions**

- In this section, you must create **one** written text (**not** including song, poetry or verse).
 - In your text, you must include meaningful connections with ideas drawn from
 - **one** of the Frameworks of Ideas
 - the title provided for your selected Framework of Ideas
 - **at least one** piece of stimulus material provided for your selected Framework of Ideas
 - You must develop your text with a clear purpose, incorporating **at least one** of the following: to explain, to express, to reflect, to argue.
 - You must write an effective and cohesive text that demonstrates fluency through your selection of vocabulary, text structure(s) and language features.
 - Refer to the assessment criteria on page 17.
 - This section is worth one-third of the total marks for the examination.
-

Framework 1: Writing about country

- Write a text that explores ideas about country.
- You must use the title provided.
- You must use **at least one** of the following stimuli.

Title: 'A country is defined by its past'

Stimulus 1

'Division and disunity in a country is unnecessary.'

Stimulus 2

Stimulus 3

'My country is my comfort,
I'm making it a good place,
It is in my heart.'

Framework 2: Writing about protest

- Write a text that explores ideas about protest.
- You must use the title provided.
- You must use **at least one** of the following stimuli.

Title: 'Peace begins with us'

Stimulus 1

"Peace means solving ... differences through peaceful means; through dialogue, education, knowledge; and through humane ways."

Stimulus 2**Stimulus 3**

"But peace, like a poem,
is not there ahead of itself,
can't be imagined before it is made,
can't be known except
in the words of its making,
grammar of justice,
syntax of mutual aid."

Framework 3: Writing about personal journeys

- Write a text that explores ideas about personal journeys.
- You must use the title provided.
- You must use **at least one** of the following stimuli.

Title: 'Whom we meet on the way'

Stimulus 1

'I would rather walk with a friend in the dark, than alone in the light.'

Stimulus 2**Stimulus 3**

'Why don't you come
walk with me
through life's doorways
and heaven's eternity?'

Framework 4: Writing about play

- Write a text that explores ideas about play.
- You must use the title provided.
- You must use **at least one** of the following stimuli.

Title: 'What's the point?'

Stimulus 1

"The exhilaration of feeling alive."

Stimulus 2**Stimulus 3**

“Itsy Bitsy Spider went up the water spout,
Down came the rain, and washed poor Itsy out.
Out came the sun, and dried up all the rain,
Now Itsy Bitsy Spider went up the spout again.”

End of Section B

Section C – Analysis of argument and language**Instructions**

- In this section, you are required to analyse the use of argument(s) and language to persuade an intended audience to share the point of view expressed in an unseen persuasive text.
- Read the background information on this page and the material on pages 14 to 16, and write an analytical response to the task below.
- For the purposes of this task, the term 'language' refers to written and spoken language, and 'visuals' refers to images and graphics.
- Refer to the assessment criteria on page 17.
- This section is worth one-third of the total marks for the examination.

Task

Write an analysis of the ways in which argument(s) and written and spoken language, and visuals are used in the material on pages 14 to 16 to try to persuade the intended audience to share the point of view presented.

Background Information

The Lilac City Council recently made the decision to close the majority of the kindergartens in Lilac city which are owned and operated by Lilac council.. Only two council-operated kindergartens will remain open. FThe following petition was published online and shared on social media on behalf of a group of concerned local residents who oppose this decision. The side panel is a template message that signatories of the petition will send to the mayor of Lilac.

2, 428 of 3,000 signaturesMuhammad T. signed
2024 - 07 - 03Claire. F signed
2024 - 07 - 02Fati
202**Your details**

First Name:

Last Name:

Email:

Postcode:

Writing to: Lilac Mayor Cynthia
Timberland and the Lilac CEO Bill
Davies**Subject:** Don't Close the Doors on
Lilac!**Your Message:**Dear Lilac Mayor Cynthia Timberland
and Lilac CEO Bill Davies,I am deeply concerned that the recent
decision...**SEND MESSAGE**

Don't Lock Our Kids out of Lilac!

The recent decision by Lilac City Council to close its kindergarten services next year is one that has left our community despondent and heartbroken.

What is happening?

From 2026, 18 of the 20 council-run kindergartens will be closed.

The decision was made following a council vote that did not represent the thousands of signatories from Lilac who pledged their names against such a choice.

This is an ugly swing of the axe that will sever the community ties in our council and irrevocably change the lives of families in Lilac.

What does this mean for families?

The closure of council-run kindergartens is an immense blow to families and our children who have relied on these services for years. Our teachers and local economy will suffer as jobs disappear. The best people to support our children are the people who know them and their community the best. Forcing families to seek childcare elsewhere not only creates a greater time and transport barrier in our busy lives, but removes the sense of tight-knit community that Lilac prides itself upon. Without our kinders, the seams of Lilac will soon fray. Then there will be no nurturing hands left to mend the stray threads and weave them back together.

The essential role of kindergarten in preparing young children for a life of learning is undeniable. Kindergarten is the vital foundation on which children begin to scaffold their skills, understanding, well-being and physical health. A sound and safe foundation is the most important part of any structure. Any builder will tell you that attempting to erect walls and a roof before the level slab is in place, will be met with disaster. The representatives of Lilac need to respect the lives of their council residents and act with good judgement and integrity to help shape the futures of our children.

Will this save money?

No. As a money saving proposition, this decision is baffling. Since the state government introduced free kinder, the amount of funding a council-run kinder service receives has increased by \$800 per child. That is a huge upswing in revenue that Lilac will lose.

Parents lose too. This change means a desperate struggle to try and secure spots at a new kindergarten, with high costs. Furthermore, families may be ineligible for free kinder if they are forced to change providers.

While the carer to child ratios are better in private kinders, these have not been chosen by a majority of families in our area because they simply cannot afford the costs. We are all

suffering through a cost-of-living crisis. Grocery trips leave us gasping in horror at the staggering figure at the bottom of the list of essentials. Fuel tank warning lights are pushed to the limit in hopes the price per litre might edge below \$2.30 again. Purse strings are tightening and, as always, it is the young families and women who face the most difficult financial circumstances. Young mothers trying to return to the workforce after gifting our community with their beautiful child will now face more barriers and inequities than ever before as they are further torn between the role of a parent and maintaining a career.

Why would the council want to close the kindergartens?

The council has claimed that their facilities are not fit for purpose, yet the buildings are going to be swiftly leased to private childcare providers. This hypocrisy reveals the duplicitousness of the council. They will make one claim in one breath, and state the opposite in the following. They simply cannot be trusted.

Was there support for the decision?

Members of the Lilac community have been vocal in voicing our opposition to this proposal, but our pleas have fallen on deaf ears. Our petitions with thousands of signatories have been disregarded. Our voices have not been considered nor valued in the consultation process, and we have been given no ability to influence the decisions that directly impact us. Our councillors were not elected so that they could ignore our wishes and abandon childcare services. This shows utter disrespect to the people of Lilac. But we refuse to give up. We will continue to speak out and become louder and louder in the fight to save our kindergartens.

What can we do to stop this?

Victoria, the so-called 'Education State' cannot sit back and accept these choices. We will not be ignored. We urge locals, as well as empathetic readers who want all our children to receive high quality education and care, to sign their names to our campaign and write to the Mayor and CEO of Lilac to stop the biggest mistake in the history of Lilac.

Sign and share the petition with others so we can all tell the council why our children must retain the high-quality kindergarten education all children deserve.



Assessment criteria

Section A will be assessed against the following criteria:

- knowledge and understanding of the text, its structure, and the ideas, concerns and values it explores
- development of a coherent analysis in response to the topic
- use of evidence from the text to support the analysis
- use of fluent expression through appropriate use of vocabulary and conventions of Standard Australian English

Section B will be assessed against the following criteria:

- use of relevant idea(s) drawn from one Framework of Ideas, the title provided and at least one piece of stimulus material
- creation of a cohesive text that connects to a clear purpose(s) and incorporates an appropriate voice
- use of suitable text structures and language features to create a text
- use of fluent expression, including the appropriate use of vocabulary

Section C will be assessed against the following criteria:

- understanding of contention, argument(s), and point of view
- analysis of ways in which written and spoken language and visual are used to present an argument(s) and to persuade an intended audience
- use of evidence from the text to support the analysis
- use of fluent expression through appropriate use of vocabulary and conventions of Standard Australian English

Sources: Tenzin Gyatso ([p.10](#)); Pexels.com ([p.10](#)); Adapted from Denise Levertov, 'Making Peace' ([p.10](#)); Adapted from Helen Keller, 'The Story of My Life' ([p.11](#)); depositphotos.com ([p.11](#)); Adapted from Amy H, 'Walk with Me' ([p.11](#)); Unknown author, 'Itsy Bitsy Spider' ([p.12](#)); Microsoft Copilot, 'Kindergarten Lockers with a Big Chain' ([p.16](#))

ENGLISH

Written examination



2025 Trial Examination

SECTION C SAMPLE RESPONSE

This sample response offers an extended analysis of the piece with the intention of helping students understand what they could have written about across the entire text. It is longer than the 800-1000 words students are expected to write themselves.

The petition created by local residents of the city of Lilac seeks to garner further support in imploring the Lilac council to reverse its decision to close its council-run kindergartens. The group appeals to locals of Lilac, as well as readers outside of this area who can lend support to their cause, based on a shared belief in the value of affordable and quality education. Addressing the petition message to the mayor of Lilac, Cynthia Timberland, and the CEO of the city, Bill Davies, reflects the groups' campaign to reverse the closure of council-run kindergartens.

The authors of the petition begin by emphasising the significant negative impacts of the decision to close council run kindergartens. Sympathy is evoked through emotive terms 'despondent' and 'heartbroken' which emphasise the detrimental impacts the choice has had on the emotional wellbeing of residents. The decision itself is metaphorically presented as an 'ugly swing of the axe', characterising the choice as violent and attacking. In this metaphor the connections that exist between residents of Lilac are the victims, with the fabric of the community being the target for the strike of the axe. Lilac residents aim to evoke further concern among readers that these impacts will extend beyond the immediate time period and into the future, implying that the community of Lilac will suffer an "irrevocable" change leaving their council area unable to be repaired and restored by subsequent councillors.

The petition then moves to consider those who are most likely to be invested in and negatively impacted by the council's decision. The axe metaphor is extended as "families" are presented as the group who will suffer the greatest "blow", furthering the idea that the council is attacking its residents. The possessive pronoun "our" creates a sense of shared responsibility for the wellbeing of local teachers and children, urging readers to seek to protect them from this choice. This approach aims to instil all residents of Lilac with a desire

to protect the community, as even if they are not parents, they are positioned as having a direct relationship with the young people in their township. Furthermore, empathy is extended to families, and parents are targeted through sympathetic reference to their “busy lives”, with the implication stress on parents will increase with this closure.

A moral argument is then developed in urging readers and councillors to prioritise the education of the next generation. Motifs of caregiving and creation are intertwined as kindergarten is described as “essential” and “vital”. This loaded language suggests that kindergarten is a crucial and non-negotiable part of a child’s development, urging readers to fear for the children in Lilac if they are deprived of these formative experiences in light of closures. The analogy of building a house consolidates the image of kindergarten as the essential starting point in a person’s life and education. The authors liken kindergarten to the foundation of a house, suggesting that if this crucial moment in life is not met with ideal support and care, any subsequent learning in primary school or high school will be jeopardised as these new structures are likely to topple when placed upon a wobbly floor. The authors subtly imply that the councillors of Lilac are making an immoral, poor and disrespectful decision by suggesting what Lilac “should” be doing (acting with “respect”, “good judgement” and “integrity”). This creates an opposition between the choice to close kinders and the actions residents would hope their councillors would take on their behalf, which by implication are “wrong” when placed against “the right direction.” This visual of children’s lockers, ironically being locked up, compounds this message of children being unfairly treated and limited by their councillors. The vibrant colours and personalised stickers on the locker present an image of kindergartens as catering to individuals in a safe and joyful environment. The oversized padlock and chains that are draped across the lockers symbolise the intervention of the Lilac council and suggest they are barring children from these positive environments. The chains extend over the space where the names of the children might be included, obscuring them and implying that each child’s individuality will be lost when they are ‘locked out’ of the kindergartens where they have made a space for themselves and found a sense of belonging.

The authors extend concerns regarding these closures to financial wellbeing, both for Lilac as a whole, and individual residents. The previously mentioned “swing” of the axe is contrasted to the “upswing” in revenue that locally owned kindergartens create. This encourages councillors and residents to worry about the negative financial impacts behind the choice. Furthermore, the authors monopolise upon commonly shared financial concerns in the midst of the cost-of-living crisis currently impacting Australians, particularly those in the middle and lower economic classes. As these families are unable to easily afford a transition to a more expensive privately owned kindergarten, this group are targeted as being those suffering the most, and set to suffer even more. Anecdotes of common price inflation around fuel and grocery prices are used to establish a connection with readers based on shared understanding of everyday financial concerns in the current Australian economic climate. Specific appeals to women are then made, likening the closure to another disadvantage that women will disproportionately face based on their gender, compared to male counterparts. This appeals to feminist values as “young mothers” are seen as continuing to face disadvantage for fulfilling the benevolent role of “gifting” Lilac with children and fulfilling the role of a parent. In this manner, the authors of the petition are seen to be supporting women and seeking more support and equality for them in society.

Lilac councillors are more directly attacked as the arguments continue. This gradual increase in hostility and direct criticism enables the authors to seem more reasonable and justified in levelling this attack, as the reasons for their concerns have been previously well established. The council are characterised as untrustworthy and insincere through descriptions of their “duplicitousness” and “hypocrisy”. These negative connotations are supported by preceding these words with reference to the council making contradictory claims about the suitability of the kindergarten buildings, offering further justification to defend and support the attack. The authors of the petition undermine the councillors of Lilac, suggesting they are not fulfilling their elected duties by ignoring residents. This encourages local readers to feel their previous support of councillors in electing them to their positions has not been returned. Repetition of words associated with protest and noise such as “pleas”, “speak out” and “louder and louder” encourage readers to believe locals have taken continual and sustained action to stop the decision. However, they argue that this hard work has not led to positive change because of the actions or lack of action of councillors who remain “deaf” and “ignore” locals, opposite behaviours to those expected by elected officials.

The petition ends with a call to action that encourages readers to believe that even though the decision has been made, there is still the chance to have it reversed. The authors describe themselves as being tenacious and unwilling to “give up”, encouraging readers to share their hope for change. They urge readers to share in this positive characterisation of resilience by “urging” them to join their cause. Clear instructions are provided for how to help, by signing and sharing the petition. This helps the authors meet their purpose of not only positioning locals against the decision, but compelling them to take some kind of action to lend their support in persuading Lilac councillors to reverse their decision. This purpose is further supported by the side panel on the first page. The authors have created a template for readers to use to begin their message to Lilac Mayor Cynthia Timberland and Lilac CEO Bill Davies. This makes it increasingly easy and convenient for readers to take action and sign. Furthermore, including the number of signatories and the names of others who have recently signed their support creates the sense that the majority of Lilac is against the decision, urging readers to sign with this majority. The names help to personalise the cause and suggest to readers that the numbers provided are authentic and trustworthy. Readers may also be more inclined to sign their name and send the message, seeing that other people have done so before them, mitigating potential concerns that they may be targeted in a response or drawn into lengthier correspondence than they may wish.